The passive voice

Goal: To turn active sentences into the passive voice in different tenses and with modals, and to know when the passive is preferred in scientific texts.

The idea in two lines: In the passive, the object of the active sentence becomes the subject, and the focus moves from the doer to the action. The form is always be + past participle, with *be* in the tense of the active verb.

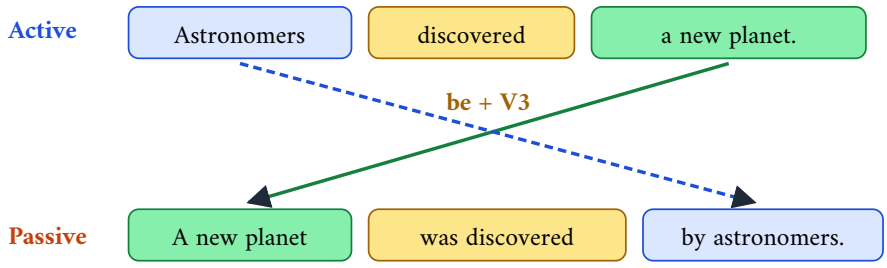


Figure 1: The object moves to the subject position; the doer becomes an optional agent after *by*.

🔵 Rules and concepts

1. **Form:** object → subject + be (same tense) + past participle (+ by agent).
2. **Present / past simple:** *is / are observed*; *was / were observed*.
3. **Continuous:** *is being built*; *was being built*.
4. **Perfect:** *has / have been sent*; *had been sent*.
5. **Future and modals:** will / can / must / should + be + V3.
6. **Agent:** omit *by + agent* when it is unknown, obvious or unimportant (*by people, by someone*).
7. **Impersonal passive:** *It is believed that… / The Moon is said to…*

🟢 Examples

1. *Scientists are launching a new satellite.* **Solution:** A new satellite **is being launched** (by scientists).

2. *They have sent robots to Mars.* **Solution:** Robots **have been sent** to Mars. **Explanation:** *they* is a vague agent, so it is omitted.
3. *People say that the universe is expanding.* **Solution: It is said that** the universe is expanding / The universe **is said to be** expanding.

🟠 Common BAC mistakes

- Changing the tense: the tense of *be* must match the active verb.
- Forgetting agreement: *The stars was seen → were seen.*
- Using the past simple form instead of the past participle: *was builded / was wrote.*
- Keeping *by them / by people* when the agent is vague.

🟡 Quick review

- Passive = be (active tense) + V3.
- Continuous: being; perfect: been.
- Modal + be + V3.
- Drop vague agents; use *It is said that…* for opinions.

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